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# *Vachellia seyal*

***Vachellia seyal***, the **red acacia**, known also as the **shittah tree** (the source of **shittim wood**), is a thorny, 6– to 10-m-high (20 to 30 ft) tree with a pale greenish or reddish bark. At the base of the 3–10 cm (1.2–3.9 in) feathery leaves, two straight, light grey thorns grow to 7–20 cm (2.8–7.9 in) long. The blossoms are displayed in round, bright yellow clusters about 1.5 cm (0.59 in) diameter.

In *Vachellia seyal* var. *fistula*, which is more common on heavy clay soils, some of the thorns are swollen and house symbiotic ants.[2]

It is distributed from Egypt to Kenya and west to Senegal. In the Sahara, it often grows in damp valleys. It is also found at *wadis* on the Arabian Peninsula.

| Red acacia |
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| Scientific classification | |
|---|---|
| Kingdom: | Plantae |
| *Clade*: | Tracheophytes |
| *Clade*: | Angiosperms |
| *Clade*: | Eudicots |
| *Clade*: | Rosids |
| Order: | Fabales |
| Family: | Fabaceae |
| Subfamily: | Caesalpinioideae |
| *Clade*: | Mimosoid clade |
| Genus: | *Vachellia* |
| Species: | ***V. seyal*** |

| Binomial name |
|---|
| ***Vachellia seyal*** (Delile) P.J.H.Hurter |

| Varieties |
|---|
| ▪ *Vachellia seyal* var. *fistula* (Schweinf.) Kyal. & Boatwr. |

## Varieties

Two varieties are recognized:[3][4]

- *Vachellia seyal* var. *fistula* (Schweinf.) Kyal. & Boatwr.
- *Vachellia seyal* var. *seyal* (Delile) P.J.H.Hurter

## Hybrids

*Vachellia seyal* occasionally hybridizes with *V. xanthophloea*.

## Uses

### Gum arabic

*Vachellia seyal* is, along with other *Vachellias*, an important source for gum arabic, a natural polysaccharide, that exudes from damaged stems and solidifies.[5] The gum of *V. seyal* is called *gum talha*, from Arabic طلح *ṭalḥ*, a term for any fruiting tree.

### Tanning

Parts of the tree have a tannin content up to 18-20%. The bark and seed pods of *V. seyal* var. *seyal* have a tannin content around 20%.[4]

## Wood

Wood from the tree is said to have been used in Ancient Egypt to make coffins and also the Ark of the Covenant.[6]

## Medicinal uses

### Bark

The bark is used to treat dysentery and bacterial infections of the skin, such as leprosy. It is also used as a stimulant.[5]

### Gum

The gum is used as an aphrodisiac, to treat diarrhoea, as an emollient, and to treat hemorrhaging, inflammation of the eye, intestinal ailments, and rhinitis. It is used to ward off arthritis and bronchitis.[5]

### Wood

Incense from the wood is used to treat pain from rheumatism and to keep expectant mothers from contracting rhinitis and fevers.[5]

- *Vachellia seyal* var. *seyal* (Delile) P.J.H.Hurter

**Synonyms**[1]

- *Acacia fistula* Schweinf.
- *Acacia flava* (Forssk.) Schweinf. var. *seyal* (Delile) Roberty
- *Acacia seyal* Delile
- *Acacia stenocarpa* A.Rich.

*Vachellia seyal* bark

Acacia tree in Ain Khudra Oasis, Nuweiba, Sinai Peninsula, Egypt

*Vachellia seyal*

# See also

- Talhah (name)

# References


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5. Purdue University (http://www.hort.purdue.edu/newcrop/duke_energy/Acacia_seyal.html)

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